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bought in a show,” says Manvendra Singh Barwani, automotive historian and the curator of the Oberoi Concours d’Elegance.

After India gained Independence, import of cars for personal use was prohibited under the Licence Raj and only embassies were allowed to import, says Barwani.

The value of vintage cars fell subsequently, prompting buyers from other countries to buy these. As a result, many of these cars left India, including the one belonging to the Maharaja of Kashmir.

There was a time when Rolls-Royce was an established brand in India, says Irene Nikkein, Regional Director Asia-Pacific, Rolls-Royce Motor Cars. “The Maharajas had a very strong appreciation of it. Over the years, there have been some changes in the market with duties and taxes. Of course, there was a

natural decline. Over the last few years, we saw it slowly picking up again,” says Nikkein.

Things turned a corner in 2013 as the government allowed import of vehicles manufactured before 1950.

“India has around 6,000 vintage cars from the British era. About 300 cars have been recently imported after the government allowed people to import,” says Barwani.

These rules were further eased in February 2025, as the government notified new norms allowing import of cars older than 50 years. All this has spawned a new crop of vintage car collectors and restorers in India who don’t let lack of available auto parts to come in the way of their passion.

Passion is probably the key factor that drives collectors, says Poonawalla. “You always have to

be on the lookout because these cars are in different parts of the world. Getting them all together is no mean task. I have been working on them for the last 20 years. And no single collector has put together this Phantom showcase at any one single event. It is very special,” says Poonawalla, whose showcase of seven Phantom cars included a 1979 Rolls-Royce Phantom VI previously owned by Queen Elizabeth II. “It is a logistical nightmare to get them all together at one spot at the same time.”

Passionate collectors—mostly businessmen who like to splurge on flamboyant automobiles and a few descendants of royal families from erstwhile princely states—go above and beyond to restore these cars.

Pallab Roy, a vintage car collector who belongs to the Cosimbazar royal family in West